

● MTLE 5001 · MIDTERM

Market & Customer Discovery

A MISO research report on remote pet companionship

Group 6 · October 2026

Interview

5

Media

15

Survey

31

Observation

3



Research at a glance



Four MISO tools, deliberately paired so that each one covers another one's blind spot.

INTERVIEW 5 Depth Owners across three living situations: alone, abroad, at a shop, at a farm.	MEDIA 15 Context Industry data, competitor pricing, and cat behaviour science.	SURVEY 31 Scale Separation frequency, satisfaction, automation limits, price ceiling.	OBSERVATION 3 Behaviour Shop, home and public settings — what pets actually do.
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PAIRING	PURPOSE IN THIS PROJECT
Interview × Survey	Surveys give scale; interviews give the reasons behind the percentages.
Interview × Observation	Checks whether what owners say matches what they and their pets actually do.
Media × Interview	Explains the “why” behind industry trends — e.g. why cameras alone under-deliver.



Interview is the mandatory tool.
Three supporting tools were run in parallel so that every claim can be checked against a second source.

● Research design

Goals & Hypotheses



Three hypotheses, each with a stated falsification condition.

RESEARCH QUESTION

How might we help pet owners feel informed and connected with their cats during everyday separation, while respecting the cat’s natural behaviour and rest?

H1

Separation is a daily condition

Owners are routinely apart from their pets — not only when travelling.

FALSIFIED IF most owners are apart fewer than 3 days a month.

H2

Cameras give visibility, not response

Owners can see the pet but cannot act on what they see.

FALSIFIED IF owners can act in time on what the camera shows.

H3

Automation only inside owner-set boundaries

Owners accept automation, but must control when and how it happens — and it must not disturb the pet.

FALSIFIED IF owners accept full autonomy or disregard pet disturbance.

!

H2 was refined by the field interviews.

The gap is not “seeing” — it is acting on what is seen. Visibility without a response path changes nothing.

● Method

Why MISO — what each tool reveals, and what it hides



We chose the tools for their blind spots, then paired them so the blind spots cancel out.

SURVEY

REVEALS

Patterns, frequency, scale

BLIND SPOT

Shallow, self-reported

31 respondents — separation frequency and price ceiling.

INTERVIEW

REVEALS

Meaning, emotions, reasoning

BLIND SPOT

Rationalisation bias

5 owners — the reasons behind the percentages.

OBSERVATION

REVEALS

Actual behaviour, workarounds

BLIND SPOT

Small sample; interpretation

3 settings — who initiates interaction and what interrupts rest.

MEDIA

REVEALS

Norms, discourse, social context

BLIND SPOT

Loud voices, extremes

15 sources — industry, competitors, cat behaviour science.



Known failure modes we guarded against:

leading questions, confirmation bias, and treating an owner's own explanation as an observation.



Interview design & question preparation

Ten questions prepared in advance, plus a documented follow-up set.

TARGET & RECRUITMENT

- **Strong bond, unable to be present**
Three situations: long working hours, long distance, delegated care.
- **Convenience and snowball sampling**
No requirement that the participant wants a product — disagreement is valuable.
- **Three interview contexts**
Students abroad (text), a shop owner and a farm household (in person).
- **Consent and anonymisation**
Participants briefed on course use; real names replaced with codes I1–I5.

THE 10 PREPARED QUESTIONS · 5 BLOCKS

BLOCK	FOCUS
1 · Bond	The pet's role in daily life
2 · Separation	Feelings and worries when leaving
3 · Current care	Cameras, family, boarding — what works
4 · Friction	Moments that increase anxiety instead of easing it
5 · Concept	Desired feedback; gentle vs intrusive interaction

PROBING RULE

Open questions only — "Can you describe...", "How did that feel...". Documented for every interview: answers, inconsistencies, and at least 5 follow-up questions.

The five interviews



Two very different kinds of separation emerged from the same five conversations.

ID	PROFILE	PET	LIVING SITUATION	FORMAT	EVIDENCE
I1	Christian, 25, internet industry, lives alone	Ragdoll, 4y	Apartment, alone	WeChat text	Transcript + photos
I2	Randy, 23, overseas student	American Shorthair, 2y	Family home, owner abroad	WeChat text	Transcript + photos
I3	James, overseas student	2 Toy Poodles	Family home, owner abroad	WeChat text	Written record
I4	Barbershop owner, ~30, bar shift to 5am	Two cats	Live in the shop	In person · 1h	Field notes
I5	Neighbour, 22–23, family farm	One cat + dog	Farm, 1 hour away	In person · 10m	Photos



Two kinds of absence, two different product needs.

Owners separated by time (night shifts, time zones) and owners separated by distance and delegated care do not want the same thing.

● Interview evidence

I1–I3 · Owners separated by time



Remote owners describe a loop that closes badly: they check, they worry more, they still cannot rest.

4/5

describe a routine, daily separation

Separation is caused by work schedules, time zones or study abroad — not by occasional travel.

"He's not just a pet, he's my family."
— I1, 25, lives alone

4/5

report that checking can increase anxiety

Cameras confirm safety, but seeing the pet wait alone often deepens worry rather than easing it.

"Seeing her at the door all day makes me worry more — what if she's lonely or unwell?"
— I2, overseas student

3/5

want a more meaningful connection

They ask for automatic highlight clips, insight into their pet's state, and two-way interaction — not another one-way voice call.

"I don't just want to see her. I want to feel like I'm really there."
— I1, 25, lives alone



The same disappointment appears in three interviews.

Calling through the camera makes the pet search for the owner and then give up — owners describe guilt, not reassurance.

● Interview evidence

I4–I5 · Owners separated by distance and place

Both have a camera. The camera does not do the same job for either of them.



I4 · BARBERSHOP OWNER

- Cats live permanently in the shop; he arrives about 1pm, starts cutting at 2pm, then works at a bar until 5am
- He believes cats need no dedicated play — “cats are not like dogs”
- He bought several toys; the cats ignored them, so he concluded toys are unnecessary
- The cats usually walk up to people on their own; the two cats behave very differently
- Loud hip-hop plays in the shop and repeatedly interrupts the cats’ sleep
- The camera is for “managing” the cats — in practice he watches the shop from the bar

I5 · FARM HOUSEHOLD

- Cat and dog are housed at the family farm, about a one-hour drive from home
- He visits roughly three to four days a week; workers feed the animals “on the way”
- His father runs the farm but has little interest in the pets; the family found keeping a pet at home troublesome
- He worries about the many stray dogs nearby — another dog was previously killed
- The camera shows him the situation, but he cannot act on what he sees in time
- He would welcome a device that helps with care and interaction, but has never bought one



Same technology, different task.

One camera is a shop-management tool; the other is a remote-care tool that fails at the response step.

● Interview technique

Follow-up questions log



Probing moved every conversation from opinion to event. Five are documented here.

ID	INITIAL ANSWER	FOLLOW-UP ASKED	WHAT IT WAS MEANT TO SURFACE
I4	"Cats don't need to be managed much."	Which things need no attention at all, and which do you still do every day?	Separate ambient care from interactive care
I4	"The cats usually walk up to me."	When was the most recent time? Which cat? What did you do then?	Turn a generalisation into a concrete event
I4	"I bought toys but they ignored them."	What toys, how were they placed, did you play with them, how long did you try?	Recover the process, not the conclusion
I5	"I visit three to four days a week."	On the days you don't go, how do you know how the cat is doing?	Resolve the contradiction with "I can't get there often"
I5	"The camera shows me, but I can't respond in time."	What did you do last time? Who did you contact, how long did it take, how did it end?	Map the response chain and locate the break



Inconsistencies were recorded, not smoothed over.

Where an owner's explanation and the observable behaviour disagreed, both were kept — that gap is where the opportunity sits.

● Observation

Three settings, and the behaviour we recorded

Observation checks whether what owners say matches what actually happens.



S1 · Barbershop

5 Oct 2026 · afternoon

Shop owner, 2 staff, walk-in customers

Resting place; scratching of the sofa; sleep interrupted by music; distance kept from people

S2 · Owner's home

To be scheduled

Single-person household, cat alone in daytime

Camera and feeder positions; blind spots in coverage; where the cat rests; door and window risks

S3 · Public setting

To be scheduled

Owners with pets in an unfamiliar environment

Stress signals of the pet; owner's calming actions; changes in distance; phone-checking frequency

FIELD NOTE FROM S1 (RECORDED)

- The shop has a cat tree and a sofa — the cats still scratch the sofa, so "nowhere to scratch" is not the explanation
- Within the observed period, the cats did not knock over any of the many bottles and instruments on site
- Loud hip-hop plays regularly and repeatedly interrupts the cats' sleep



What secondary research adds: 15 sources, 5 findings

Industry & market (3) · peer-reviewed & veterinary guidance (4) · user reviews (4) · vendor & media (4)

FINDING FROM SECONDARY SOURCES	SOURCES	WHAT IT MEANS FOR US
The market is large, but the smart-companion hardware slot is small	S1, S2	Food + medical = 81.3% of pet spending. The emotional need is acknowledged; payment concentrates elsewhere.
Living alone and younger owners is a structural trend	S3, S1, S2	The segment exists and is growing — but macro statistics cannot predict individual purchase.
Cats cope with being alone, yet only respond to the owner's voice and cat-directed speech	S4, S7, S5	Remote audio must use the owner's own voice, be low-frequency and predictable. "No response" is a normal result.
Real camera complaints are false alerts, startling the pet, dropouts and subscriptions	S8, S11, S15, S6	Differentiate on fewer interruptions and more reliable judgement; multi-cat identification is a must-have.
Competitors sell companionship as hardware + subscription, but the cat offer stops at meow alerts	S12–S15	The open space is understanding plus non-intrusive, owner-controlled interaction.



Source codes refer to the supporting document.
“13-Media研究报告” lists all 15 sources with live URL and access date (2026-10-06).

Media

Three weaknesses in the secondary findings

Secondary research was treated as a source of hypotheses, not of proof.



B1

Vendor and commercial content pollutes search ranking

The top-ranked "review" was flagged as containing AI-generated content, cited labs we could not verify, and ended with a promotion. A widely-cited cat-sitting guide is itself AIGC aggregation.

HOW WE HANDLED IT

Only official, verifiable features and pricing were used. Unverifiable figures were discarded entirely.

B2

Review channels suffer self-selection and survivorship bias

The same product scores 4.8/5 on the official store, while an aggregator rates 67.1% of 5,461 reviews negative. One reviewer notes positive raters "just received the product".

HOW WE HANDLED IT

Reviews were used only to identify the kinds of pain points and their language — never to infer proportions.

B3

Samples and definitions are not comparable

Cat behaviour evidence comes from 14 Swedish cats and 16 French cats; Chinese material skews urban, young and female; two different market-size definitions are often mixed.

HOW WE HANDLED IT

Every behavioural claim is reported with its sample size. All figures carry an explicit sample boundary.

!

Research gap stated openly:

no first-hand platform evidence for cat-owner complaints (review sites require login), and the primary literature on cat ultrasound could not be accessed.

● Survey

What the survey adds: scale



31 respondents. The percentages turned our interview themes into a measurable pattern.

74.2%

separated ≥4h on 3+ days a week

23 of 31 — a daily pattern, not occasional travel.

80.6%

worried about their pet, at least sometimes

And 74.2% feel they lack enough information.

32.3%

satisfied with their current setup

Only about a third — on both knowing and feeling connected.

71%

accept automation within limits they set

Only 6.5% reject automation entirely.

THE CONTRADICTION WORTH EXAMINING

Owner-initiated voice / toy interaction

71% rate it valuable (22 of 31) — owners say it is useful...

Pick the single most important feature

1 respondent chose it (3.2%). Useful ≠ a reason to purchase.



The interviews explain the gap.

I4 had already tried toys, they failed, and he concluded interactive devices are unnecessary — a second failed attempt closes the need permanently.

Synthesis

Triangulation · insight validation grid



We looked for contradictions as well as confirmations, then rated each insight by how many sources support it

INSIGHT	INTERVIEW (N=5)	SURVEY (N=31)	MEDIA	OBSERVATION	CONFIDENCE
Separation is frequent and daily	4/5 describe routine separation	74.2% ≥3 days/week	S1–S3	—	High
Seeing the pet is not reassurance	I1, I2, I3: anxiety rises after checking	Satisfaction 32.3%	S8, S15	—	High
Response capability, not visibility, is the gap	I2, I5 cannot act on what they see	51.6% fear disturbing the pet	—	S1 owner absent at night	Medium
Pets initiate interaction	I4 yes / I5 no	—	S4, S7 (n=14/16)	Cats walk up to people	Low — conflicting
Devices must not disturb the pet	I4: shop music already disrupts sleep	51.6% barrier	S5, S6	Direct observation	Medium-High



The pet-initiated interaction finding runs in opposite directions.

One owner’s cats approach people on their own; another’s cat is not clingy. It cannot be generalised from this sample — and it is the premise the concept rests on.

● Findings

Key findings



Six findings, ordered by how strongly they are supported across the four tools.

01

Separation is a daily condition, not an occasional event

74.2% of respondents are away for 4+ consecutive hours on 3+ days a week. Design for a routine, not for travel.

02

Cameras deliver visibility, not reassurance

Only 32.3% are satisfied. Watching a pet that waits alone often increases anxiety instead of reducing it.

03

The real gap sits after the camera, in response capability

I5 can see the cat but is an hour away; I4 can see the shop from the bar but cannot act. Visibility without response.

04

Care chains rest on fragile arrangements

Feeding depends on workers passing by, and the person who cares most is not the person on site. A camera cannot fix who is present.

05

Owners accept automation only within boundaries they set

71 % accept bounded automation; only 6.5% reject it outright. The desired model is human-in-the-loop.

06

Pet-initiated interaction is real but inconsistent

One owner's cats approach people; another's cat is not clingy. This cannot be generalised yet — and the concept rests on it.



Potential biases & limitations

These limits are stated so the findings are read at the right strength.

#	LIMITATION	HOW IT AFFECTS THE FINDINGS
1	Small samples — 5 interviews, 31 survey responses	Percentages are unstable; 1 respondent = 3.2%. Findings are existence proofs, not population estimates.
2	Text-based interviews for I1–I3	Answers are more composed and complete than in speech, with less spontaneity — this can flatter the interviewer’s questions.
3	Convenience and acquaintance sampling	Participants are friends, a neighbour and a customer; social-desirability bias is likely.
4	Interviewer bias	The interviewer is afraid of cats, which may affect how cat behaviour was observed and interpreted.
5	Owner explanations recorded as data	For I4 especially, the owner’s account (“cats need no play”) coexists with contradictory behaviour. Both are reported separately.
6	Interviewer inference vs participant statements	“Guilt while watching the camera” was the interviewer’s inference, not a participant’s words. It is flagged as a hypothesis.
7	Photographic evidence incomplete	On-site photos exist for I5 only; I4 photos and consent records are pending.

● Direction

What this changes for the design



The research moves the problem statement, and leaves three questions open.

SHIFT THE PROBLEM STATEMENT

- From “help owners see their pet” to “help owners act when it matters”
- From “more features” to “a response path that actually closes”
- From full autonomy to owner-defined boundaries the system operates inside

OPEN QUESTIONS FOR THE NEXT ROUND

- Who is the local responder when the owner is an hour away?
- What is the minimum interaction a cat will initiate repeatedly?
- How quiet must a device be in an already noisy environment?

VALIDATION STEP

Test whether cats re-engage with a device

Test the response-path concept

Test sound tolerance in a noisy room

METHOD

Observation in 3 homes over 1 week

Prototype a care-log + contact escalation

Companion observation in the barbershop

WHAT WOULD FALSIFY OUR DIRECTION

Cats approach once and never return

Owners say the camera is already enough

The cat shows no reaction to added sound



Every claim above is bounded by the limits on the previous slide.
These are directions for validation, not validated results.

Interview documentation (photos)



Replace each frame with the corresponding image and keep the caption.

PHOTO 1

I4 — the barbershop owner with one of his cats, inside the shop

PHOTO 2

I4 — cat tree and sofa; the camera's mounting position

PHOTO 3

I4 — phone live view of the shop (blur account details)

PHOTO 4

I5 — the participant on site at the family farm

PHOTO 5

I5 — the house where the cat is kept, and the dog's tether point

PHOTO 6

I1 / I2 — the pets of the remote owners (provided by participants)



Blur names, avatars, addresses and device IDs before submission.
Photos provided by participants are labelled as such and are not presented as researcher observation.